



Setting Expectations

APPENDIX A: Setting expectations with your advisor

Who is my advisor?

When you enter into a research-based graduate course you are often matched with a faculty member or external advisor who will supervise or oversee your major research paper (MRP). The individual who ends up being the primary supervisor for your MRP is your advisor. This individual is primarily responsible for your academic and research success; however, we encourage you during meetings with them to discuss your short-term and medium/long term goals. Keeping your advisor up to date with your projected goals can help them better advise you academically and share opportunities that support your career and academic goals.

Clarifying expectations with your faculty advisor

The next page provides a helpful guide of topics for graduate students to discuss with potential or confirmed advisors. This list is not exhaustive and some topics may not make sense in certain disciplines. The intent of the worksheet is to encourage explicit and open dialogue between an advisor and student on key aspects of a research-based graduate degree. The document can help clarify items that are sometimes left implicit and hence prone to misunderstanding.

In the same vein, this is not a contract. Completing graduate research with an advisor is not akin to contracting research as would a client of a consultant. Each party can certainly hold [reasonable expectations of the other](#), but it is best based on reciprocity rather than rights. The best advisor-student relationship is one where both parties benefit by looking out for each others' interests.

Please use this worksheet in the spirit in which it was developed. Students should fill out the worksheet and then have a conversation with their advisor. At the end of your conversation offer to send the agreed expectations to the advisor for their record. The expectation worksheet was adapted from **McGill University and Research Supervisor @ Oxford**.



Setting Expectations

Items to discuss	Student	Advisor(s)
Post-completion/graduation goals: - What are your post-graduation expectations? - What are your expectations about how your faculty advisor will help you with your post-graduation goals?	I am still exploring my options, but leaning toward industry or biotech roles. This research experience will help me decide. Guidance on career paths in bioinformatics or research, and a reference letter if my work meets expectations.	Agreed. To have contributed to a competitive skill set for subsequent job search. Maintain contact as a mentor and provide reference as required.
Research Focus What is your vision for your research focus?	Understand what drives the fate decision between regenerative (TSPC) and fibrotic (T-FAP) tendon progenitor cells using scRNA-seq data, and build a gene signature that can classify healing outcomes.	Agreed.
Research Direction How much direction do you expect from your advisor?	I prefer weekly or biweekly check-ins with clear feedback at each stage. Between meetings I am comfortable working independently once I understand the task.	Agreed.
Skills and knowledge Which skills do you have and which skills does your supervisor expect you to have?	Python, scRNA-seq analysis (scanpy), Git/GitHub, data visualization, basic bioinformatics pipelines. Transcription factor network inference, cell fate trajectory analysis, machine learning for biological data.	Agreed.

Setting Expectations

Expected outcomes of the research beyond course-required components Examples: conference presentations, peer-reviewed articles, etc.,	Completing a strong portfolio project and a symposium presentation are the main goal. Co-authorship is not expected but would be appreciated if the work reaches publication quality.	Absolutely.
Turnaround times How quickly do you expect your advisor to provide feedback on work that you have submitted for review?	Within 2–3 business days for messages. Feedback on submitted work within 1–2 weeks is ideal.	It would be unusual to not respond to messages the same day and work feedback within 1-2 weeks is plenty of time.
Authorship expectations What are your expectations about authorship (especially, if you are using your supervisor's lab resources or previously collected data, etc.,)	All datasets used are publicly available. If results are publishable, I would hope to be included as a co-author — but happy to follow the lab's standard practice.	Any contribution resulting in published materials will be appropriately credited.
Meetings with faculty advisor: How often do you expect to meet with your advisor?	Weekly or biweekly, depending on the project phase.	Agreed. Supervisor can be flexible.
Communication between meetings - Does your advisor prefer to communicate by telephone or email? - How quickly do you expect a response to a phone or mail message?	Email (or Slack). A response within 2–3 business days is expected for non-urgent questions.	No problem.
Expectations for written work - Does your advisor expect to receive your completed MRP all at once? Or do they expect drafts of chapters as they are complete? - Do they expect drafts to be polished? - How often should you submit work? - What is your expectation about the best format for receiving feedback?	Happy to submit drafts section by section as they are completed rather than all at once. Feedback via inline comments or verbally during meetings — either works.	Flexible.

Setting Expectations

Expectations about data availability • Data ownership • Data privacy • Timeline to provide data generated during the project	All primary datasets are from public repositories (GEO/SRA). Ownership of any derived data to be discussed and agreed upon with supervisor. No patient or sensitive data is used — all data is published and publicly available. Processed datasets and figures will be available on the GitHub repository throughout the project.	Agreed. Unpublished data from the lab will remain confidential until publication.
Expectations about code availability • Code ownership • Code privacy • Github repository	To be discussed. My preference is to keep the code on a shared GitHub repository so it benefits future lab members. Public repository is preferred, but I will follow the lab's policy. All analysis notebooks and scripts will be version-controlled and documented.	Agreed. Unpublished data from the lab will remain confidential until publication
Other expectations •	None at this time. Open to revisiting this worksheet mid-project if expectations change.	Agreed.